

Impact

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CAPTION See story below.

What's a Parent to Do? Micah's College Dream

by Janice Fialka

My father proudly graduated from the University of Michigan in 1948, the first in his family of 11 children. Little did he know he established a generational pattern for the important men in my life. My two brothers, several cousins, and my husband all claim the same “maize-and-blue.” At the age of 5, our son, Micah, attended his first U of M football game and was immediately awestruck by the “Go Blue!” spirit. I sensed he felt destined to follow in the footsteps of his Papa, father, and uncles. He didn’t have the words to express this dream – words did not come easily to him then – but his dream was deepened with every U of M game he attended.

We as parents wanted both our children, Micah and Emma, to have dreams. Dreams motivate our spirit, drive us forward, stretch us in new directions, and compel us to try new things. We wanted our children to gradually feel the pull of passion and purpose. But what if their dreams are met with words like, “unrealistic,” “impossible,” “out of reach,” “can’t do that,” “unheard of,” or simply “Why would he do THAT.....?” Those were some of the very words we heard when Micah talked about his college dream. “Look at the facts,” we were told, even by well-meaning people who cared about Micah. Fact # 1: Micah had a cognitive impairment with a low I.Q. score. Fact #2: Micah didn’t read or write (though he could sign his name after years of practice.) Fact #3: There were no fully inclusive college programs in our community. Fact #4: Youth like Micah, with an IEP, go to community-based programs after high school, not college! What’s a parent to do?

[Fialka, continued on page 34]

From the Editors

As this Impact issue is about to be published, one of the pioneers in sexuality education for persons with disabilities has just passed away. Her name is Winifred Kempton and one of the reasons this Impact issue is able to provide the depth and breadth of information it does is that she was among those who, over 40 years ago, publicly acted on her conviction that individuals with intellectual, developmental and other disabilities have the right and need to receive information about sexuality. The tools she created for sexuality education (including a dozen books as well as sexuality education programs she authored or co-authored) approached individuals with disabilities as fully-formed people with an intrinsic right to know about and participate in this part of the human experience. She was a genuine advocate in the truest sense, and will be missed.

Today, other pioneering voices are carrying on that advocacy and education work, and in this issue of Impact readers will have the opportunity to hear from some of them as they talk about the range of issues that are part of sexuality in its fullness. It’s our hope that the articles gathered here will provide information and inspiration that further support the right and opportunity for people with intellectual, developmental, and other disabilities to understand and express this essential dimension of human life.

What's Inside

*Overviews
Personal Profiles
Resources*

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[Fialka, continued from page 1]

Listen to the Dream

One of the first things we learned as Micah's parents was to listen to his dreams, even if they appeared "unusual." Our first experience with the "listening thing" occurred when Micah was in his first grade self-contained classroom. After four months he announced to us, "I want to go through the same door as all my friends." We were stunned, and later swayed by his insistence to move him into a general education classroom. Micah began to teach us "unusual" does not imply "impossible."

Getting Micah in a general education classrooms through 12th grade was a bit challenging. But "college" – that was something entirely different! We had no idea *how* we were going to help him get through that door. Nonetheless, Micah held steadfast. We were committed to listening to him and heard more than just "I wanna go to college." We began to hear his unspoken desires like, "Hey, I wanna be with my friends. I wanna talk about what they're talking about. I wanna tell everyone what college I'm going to. I wanna go to football games. I wanna keep learning." And maybe most importantly, "I wanna make my own choices."

As parents, we shifted our thinking (most of the time!) away from someone else's facts and words like "impossible" and turned toward "what's the next step?" This was often not easy, but always right, and eventually became a strategy for dealing with the so-called impossible. . . . keeping taking the next step!

Building the Dream

During the final two years of high school, a creative and dedicated group of college and public school professionals from Eastern Michigan University and Oakland Public Schools met to consider, and eventually create, an inclusive program where young adults with intellectual disabilities could become college students. Titled the NAME OF PROGRAM, the program is located at Oakland University in Rochester, Michigan. students in it attend classes, participate in extra-

curricular activities, and, in Micah's case, live in the dorm. At age 19 Micah entered the program and through his 7 years in it grew academically, socially, morally, and politically in dramatic ways. He studied public speaking, created Power Point™ presentations on group dynamics, studied the difference between the ways males and females greeted each other in the Student Center for a sociology class, learned to use more hand gestures when speaking, studied social movements, took a hip-hop dance class, traveled to Israel, participated at the student leadership retreat, wrote papers (maybe not 20 pages in length but two pages of facts he discovered with the support of a peer), and taught students how to use the voice-to-text software program critical to his communication. "Success" doesn't even begin to capture the extent of his growth, increased friendships and social networks, and enhanced skills to navigate the world. It wasn't a one way street either. Based on the feedback from professors, staff, and students, he made important contributions to his campus and at several others across the nation. In YEAR? he graduated from the program and today is (DOING WHAT)?

Guiding Principles

Looking back over the years, several principles guided our actions in supporting Micah's college dream:

- **Acknowledge the range of feelings.** For 12 years, Micah attended public schools. Although some days brought a struggle or two to get him what he needed, the school experience was familiar and predictable. Near the end of his senior year, I had moments of sheer panic as I thought of Micah at college. Would he be safe? Would he be teased? Would he know how to get from one end of campus to another? He wasn't even comfortable crossing a small intersection by himself – how was he going to take two public buses for one and a half hours to a campus? Feelings are part of all transitions. If we don't acknowledge them, share them with a trusting person, these

emotions return, often hindering us from moving forward. It was very important for me to communicate with a couple of mothers whose children had a disability and were about four or five years older than Micah. These mothers lived through it, survived the transition, and knew what I was feeling and needed to hear. They understood and validated my fears, worries, and even sadness at times. They also celebrated and shared my excitement. My mantra, when I remember it, is, "Feel the feelings first, with someone you trust, then move on to the next step."

- **Support great expectations.** This is a common chorus often repeated in the world of disabilities, so much so that sometimes it loses its significance and meaning. What these three words meant to us as Micah's parents was that we had to believe that Micah could learn more and do more than what was often expected of him. Finding the right supports was vital to achieving those high expectations. "He can do more" became a common chant in our family, not in a way that pressured him (we hoped), but in a way that allowed him to build on what he could do well and liked to, sprinkled with a little bit of nudging. When Micah said he wanted to go to college, believe me, we never expected that he would eventually share a film about disability history in his class on social movements. We did not know that at the beginning of each new semester, he would stand up in class and ask for a tutor to help him study (and would be thrilled that "so many pretty girls" came to his assistance). We did not know that his confidence would soar so high that he would be able to speak on his own in front of the University Board of Trustees to present his case to live in the dorm. We did not know that he would sign up to travel to Israel (gulp) or that he would discover a strong desire to read, and diligently work at it with friends or that he would find an interest in money, piqued by watching

his friends use the on-campus bank. We did not know that he would understand the word “norm” and would inform us that it was *not* the “the norm for college kids to wear boots in the winter!” He was becoming more capable almost by the day. Even brain research supports what many parents have known for years: students with intellectual disabilities do *not* stop “becoming smarter and better problem solvers” once they leave their senior year of high school. They continue to increase their problem solving skills and academic performance *if* given authentic opportunities to learn, embedded in high expectations.

- **Be mindful of the changing parental roles.** A wise sociologist once told me that there are two roles parents assume: one is the *protector* and the other is the *guide*. In the early years of raising children, the parent defends, cares for, looks after, and shields the child from harm and danger. It is easy to see how this role is often more deeply entrenched for parents of children with disabilities. We learn to be fierce advocates for our children. As they grow, parents are challenged to move away from being the constant protector to being the emerging mentor or guide. We had to step back a bit and let Micah tell his story, hand in his un-perfect paper, sign his name at the doctor’s office, make his choices about what to wear. This re-arranging of roles is not a simple transition. When Micah ended up literally stuck at his bus stop for two hours 30 miles from home in an evening snow storm that shut down the entire county, I wanted to put on my Super-Mom cape, leap over tall snow mountains, and fly him to safety. I couldn’t. We literally became his guide (thank goodness for cell phones!). We created a plan whereby his father called him every 15 minutes as he stood in a bus shelter. (He did begin to think differently about the norm of not wearing snow boots after his feet almost froze that evening!!!) After that experience his confidence increased, as did ours in

him.

- **Build relationship with allies and his peers.** Beginning in sixth grade, Micah invited a few friends to help him plan his IEP and attend part of every meeting. This involvement of friends continued into college. At his person-centered planning meetings, he always invited a few peers who participated by bringing real world solutions and insights into the discussions. They often came up with the most practical and astute ideas of how to support Micah. When Micah was in college, each year we invited him and a few of his friends or acquaintances to dinner. We kept the conversations light, fun, and we listened a lot. We learned so much. Eventually some of the peers felt comfortable sharing more ideas and questions. I recall one tutor asking me how to handle Micah’s falling asleep in an early morning class. I asked her what she would do if another friend fell asleep. She quickly said, “I would elbow him and tell him to bring a cup of coffee to class.” She instantly “got it” as evidenced in her response back to me, “Oh yeah, I get it. I guess I can do that with Micah too.” Folks need to know that it is okay to ask questions and share concerns. Micah learned to tell his tutors “You can ask me questions about my disability. I’m okay with that. I can tell you about it and how you can help me learn.”
- **Expect to live with uncertainty and risk.** I suspect that many parents raising a young adult with a disability have experienced a similar unsettling internal dialogue that goes something like this. “Do I let Micah try new thing? If I do, what if something goes wrong? What if he gets hurt? Would I have this same fear if he didn’t have an intellectual disability? But he does? So what do I do?” I’m not sure this worried-parent script will ever cease, but after more than two decades I am somewhat better at expecting these periods of anxiety. I try to be mindful of them, maybe talk with a friend or family member, create a plan, and

eventually remember to not let fear dominate my decision-making and support of Micah. My husband and I try to minimize the risks, discuss pros and cons, and practice with Micah the best ways to handle awkward or uncertain situations. But, ultimately, we realize that overprotection will only hinder his ability to make safer decisions for himself. When this happened during Micah’s years at college, I tried to practice getting more information from Micah, gaining a sense of how *he* was doing, and if necessary reach out to others. My husband and I cannot shelter Micah from all risks, nor can we do that for our daughter, Emma. Risk-taking comes with the territory for all of us.

I recently read an article by Sunny Taylor, an artist with a physical disability (CiTATION), in which she said that too often professionals and parents equate independence as having “self-care skills” such as feeding, dressing, moving about the community, banking, etc. She acknowledges that these skills can be important, but emphasized that for the person with the disability, independence is really related to being able to make your own choices for your life. “So what if my room is perfectly organized and I have my meals for a week neatly printed on my refrigerator. What if I am terribly lonely, feel bored, and don’t have a sense of accomplishment? What kind of life is that?” And for Micah making his own choices has meant going to college (with or without his winter boots!) and it’s been worth the effort and risk for all of us.

References: Citations for Sunny quote

Janice Fialka is TITLE, AFFILIATION, CITY, and Micah’s mother. She may be reached at ruaw@aol.com or PHONE. For a fuller story of Micah’s journey to learn and live inclusively on a college campus, visit www.throughthesamedoor.com.